(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)

Polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS) is a hormone condition that can affect hair growth, periods, fertility and mood. There is no cure, but treatments and lifestyle changes can help.

PMOS used to be called polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS).

Symptoms of polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)

Symptoms of polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS) usually start in girls and young women under the age of 18, at puberty, and continue until menopause. It can affect anyone who has ovaries.

After menopause, some symptoms will stop or may change.

Symptoms can be mild or severe, or you may have no symptoms at all.

The main symptoms of PMOS include:

- irregular periods or long gaps between your periods
- excessive hair growth (hirsutism) (Link: www.nhs.uk/symptoms/hirsutism/) or hair loss
- weight gain or difficulty losing weight
- difficulty getting pregnant
- mental health problems, such as depression or anxiety
- oily skin and acne
- feeling very tired
- thick, dark patches of skin on the neck or armpits (acanthosis nigricans (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/acanthosis-nigricans/))

When and where to get medical help

Some of the symptoms of polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS) are common and can be caused by many different conditions. Having them does not definitely mean you have PMOS, but it's important to get them checked.

See a GP if:

- you think you might have polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)
- your symptoms are affecting your everyday life, work and relationships

Tests for polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)

If a GP thinks you have polyendocrine metabolic syndrome (PMOS), they may arrange tests with a reproduction or hormone specialist (gynaecologist or endocrinologist).

Tests for PMOS include:

- blood tests to check hormone levels and insulin resistance
- an ultrasound scan (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/ultrasound-scan/) to look at your ovaries

An ultrasound scan will only be done if you are over 18 years old.

Treatments for polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)

There is no cure for polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS), but there are treatments and lifestyle changes that can help your symptoms.

Medicines for PMOS

PMOS symptoms are sometimes treated with:

- the combined pill (Link: www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/combined-pill/), progestogen-only pill (Link: www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/progestogen-only-pill/) or an intrauterine system (IUS) (Link: www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/ius-hormonal-coil/), to help with irregular periods
- clomifene, a medicine used to improve fertility
- spironolactone (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/spironolactone/) or eflornithine to help reduce hair growth on the face and body
- weight loss medicines if you're overweight
- metformin (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/metformin/), a type 2 diabetes medicine to help tiredness and weight problems
- skins creams or tablets that can help acne

Surgery for PMOS fertility problems

PMOS can sometimes cause problems getting pregnant. This is usually because the ovaries do not release an egg each month.

If you've tried other PMOS treatments or lifestyle changes that have not worked, a doctor may suggest a procedure called laparoscopic ovarian drilling.

This uses heat or laser to remove tissue on your ovaries and may help release more eggs. This can sometimes increase the chance of getting pregnant.

Things you can do to help polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)

If you have polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS), there are things you can do to help your symptoms.

Do

- eat a healthy, balanced diet
- exercise regularly
- try to lose weight if you're overweight
- try talking therapy if some symptoms are causing depression or anxiety
- try removing unwanted hair by shaving, waxing or using hair removal creams, or with permanent electrolysis or laser treatments

NHS help to get healthy

NHS Better Health has free tools and support to help you lose weight and get active.

Visit the NHS Better Health website (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/better-health/)

Causes of polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)

The cause of polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS) is unknown, but it may be to do with hormones such as insulin and testosterone not working properly.

You may also be more likely to have PMOS if a close relative has it or you are from an Asian background.

Complications of polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)

Polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS) can sometimes increase the risk of serious conditions, including:

- type 2 diabetes (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/type-2-diabetes/)
- high blood pressure (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/high-blood-pressure/)
- cardiovascular disease (CVD) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/cardiovascular-disease/)
- non-alcoholic fatty liver disease (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/non-alcoholic-fatty-liver-disease/)
- womb (uterus) cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/womb-cancer/)

You can reduce the risk of developing these conditions by getting regular check-ups. Talk to your doctor if you're worried.

Help and support for polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS)

Polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS) can be a difficult condition to live with, both physically and emotionally.

As well as support from your doctor, you may find it helpful to get support from charities, organisations and other people with PMOS.

British Fertility Society

The British Fertility Society (BFS) is an organisation that has information about fertility.

- Website: www.britishfertilitysociety.org.uk/ (Link: http://www.britishfertilitysociety.org.uk/)
- British Fertility Society: information for the public (Link: https://www.britishfertilitysociety.org.uk/public-resources/)

The Lowdown

The Lowdown has information about women’s health conditions, including PMOS (previously called PCOS).

- Website: www://thelowdown.com/ (Link: https://thelowdown.com/)
- The Lowdown: search PCOS experiences (Link: https://thelowdown.com/pcos/all-reviews)

The Verity

The Verity is a charity that offers information and support to anyone living with PMOS.

- Website: www.verity-pcos.org.uk/ (Link: http://www.verity-pcos.org.uk/)

Page last reviewed: 30 June 2026
Next review due: 30 June 2029